also held on to the second and third positions, respectively, since their introduction in the rankings in 2019.

Between 2018 and 2025, newer AIIMS institutions have come to occupy the top rungs in the ladder. AIIMS Jodhpur thus appears in fifth place in 2025, while AIIMS Bhopal debuts at rank 6. AIIMS Rishikesh, Raipur and Patna, too, inhabit the top 10, at ranks 7, 9 and 10, respectively. The entry of specialised institutes such as NIMHANS, Bengaluru (No. 4) and the Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences, New Delhi (No. 8) points to how medical excellence has expanded beyond general medical colleges to include research-oriented super-specialty centres.

THE TECH LANDSCAPE

When it comes to technical universities, it's no surprise that an Indian Institute of Technology rules the top. The surprise is that it's IIT Delhi that has sat firmly in the lead for five years running (2021-2025), since its rise from second place in 2018. IIT Bombay, although consistently among the top three, has slipped from No. 1 in 2018 to No. 3 this year. IIT Kanpur continues to be in second or third spot ever since it left fourth place in 2021. IIT Kharagpur, once a powerhouse that held the crown in 2018, has slipped to fourth place in 2025.

IIT Roorkee entered the top five for the first time in 2024 and is holding steady this year. Below it is IIT Guwahati, which has consistently ranked sixth since 2023 but was fourth in 2020. IIT Mandi is another institute that has shown steady improvement since its appearance in the rankings. Non-IITs are making their mark, too, with Delhi Technological University (DTU), IIIT Bangalore and BITS Pilani finding a place in the top 10 since at least 2020.

And what of the law universities? The rankings here highlight the sustained leadership of the National Law School of India University (NLSIU), Bengaluru, which has never taken leave of its numero uno status. The West Bengal National University of Juridical Sciences (NUJS), Kolkata, displays the same consistency a rung below, a position it has held every year since it re-entered the rankings in 2021.

THE UNIVERSITY ECOSYSTEM

TYPE OF UNIVERSITY	TOTAL NUMBER
CENTRAL UNIVERSITIES	57
STATE UNIVERSITIES	503
DEEMED TO BE UNIVERSITIES	145
PRIVATE UNIVERSITIES	512
TOTAL	1,217

THE EXPANDING UNIVERSE

More than 400 new universities have come up in the last decade; 54 were set up in the last one year

YEAR	NO. OF UNIVERSITIES
2015-16	799
2016-17	864
2017-18	903
2018-19	993
2019-20	1,043
2021-22	1,047
2023	1,093
2024	1,163
2025	1,217

This year's survey also introduces a critical innovation: the 'Most Improved Universities' ranking. For the first time, universities have been evaluated not merely on the basis of their current standing but also by how far they have come—from 2020 to 2025—factoring in the percentage rise in their relative rankings. This innovation has brought in a new dynamism in rankings, giving a chance to those universities that may have started from a lower base but have displayed consistent upward mobility. No longer content to be peripheral players, these universities are aggressively competing on metrics that matter, from research output, faculty strength, campus development, digital innovation to industry engagement. And in doing so, they are challenging the long-standing hegemony of legacy institutions.

By readjusting the focus from pedigree to progress, the new list incentivises resilience, adaptability and long-term reform, and marks a celebration of institutional evolution. Such methodological innovations have helped the INDIA TODAY Best Universities Survey emerge, over time, as the most authoritative and trusted barometer of higher education in India. Its credibility rests on its dual assessment system, combining objective performance indicators (based on audited data, faculty quality, research output, infrastructure and placements) with perception scores (derived from surveys of faculty, students, recruiters and alumni). The survey is also particular about strict verification standards, ensuring transparency and eliminating data misrepresentation, a frequent concern in rankings.

More than anything, the survey stands apart for its nuanced rankings: separating general, technical, medical and law universities, and further distinguishing between government and private institutions. This disaggregation allows for a fairer comparison and helps students make more informed choices. In capturing not just who leads, but who's also catching up, the survey reflects both stability and churn. By combining empirical rigour with perceptive insight, and spotlighting not just excellence but evolution, the survey affirms one thing clearly: the future of Indian higher education will be shaped as much by ambition and adaptability as by reputation. ■